

8th Grade American Studies

Realigned Curriculum Map · Revolution → Reform

Aligned to the WA Social Studies Learning Standards (2019) · Alderwood Middle School · Calendar-aligned to Edmonds SD 2026–27 · Updated July 2026

How this map is built

This realignment keeps the chronological spine your course already had and reorganizes it into **eight thematic, project-anchored units** that run from the Revolution through the Reform era. Five design choices shape it:

- **Chronology preserved.** The year still moves in order; nothing was reshuffled out of sequence.
- **One project per theme.** Each unit is anchored by a single, meaningful project rather than a string of small tasks.
- **Gaps infused, not bolted on.** Economics and geography are woven into existing units; there is no standalone “economics unit.”
- **Two anchors.** The required Civics CBA (the SCOTUS debate) closes Semester 1; a term-long Civic Action throughline closes Semester 2.
- **Built-in wiggle room.** A weekly current-events routine and flex/review weeks are scheduled, not assumed.

Year at a glance

Eight units across two semesters, plus a weekly routine and flex time. Eras past 1877 (Units 7–8) follow your district’s Revolution-to-Reform scope; see the note in the coverage check.

Calendar-aligned to the Edmonds 2026–27 year: 40 instructional weeks · 180 student days. First day Sep 2 · End Q1 Nov 6 · End Semester 1 Jan 22 (CBA due) · End Q3 Apr 2 · Last day Jun 22. Breaks: Thanksgiving Nov 25–27, Winter Dec 21–Jan 1, Spring Apr 5–9.

Unit	Theme	Weeks	Era	Signature project	New?
1	Foundations & Identity	Sep 2 – 18 (wk 1–3)	pre-1763	“Whose America?” identity study	—
2	Revolution: Ideas & Voices	Sep 21 – Oct 23 (wk 4–8)	1763–83	Voices of the Revolution podcast	—
3	Building a Government	Oct 26 – Dec 18 (wk 9–16)	1781–1815	Constitutional CBA — content & build	—
3	CBA debates + Semester 1 close	Jan 4 – 22 (wk 17–19)	—	SCOTUS debates · review · CBA due Jan 22	—
4	A New Nation & Its Economy	Jan 26 – Feb 19 (wk 20–23)	1789–1840s	“Founding an Economy” decision sim	—
5	Expansion & Its Costs	Feb 22 – Mar 19 (wk 24–27)	1801–50	Layered map + perspectives study	—
6	A Nation Divided	Mar 22 – Apr 23 (wk 28–31)	1850–77	Civil War causation + economics analysis	—
7	A Changing Nation	Apr 26 – May 21 (wk 32–35)	1877–1915	“Building Modern America” exhibit	NEW
8	Reform & Civic Action	May 24 – Jun 22 (wk 36–40)	1890–today	Civic Action Project (choice board)	NEW

Recurring all year: “Now & Then” — a 15-minute weekly current-events connection plus spiral review (H4.6-8.3, SSS1, SSS3). In Semester 2 it doubles as the engine of the Civic Action throughline.

The two anchors

Anchor 1 — Constitutional Issues CBA (the SCOTUS debate)

Your required Civics Classroom-Based Assessment lives at the end of Unit 3 and *is* the SCOTUS debate. Students argue a constitutional question through a landmark Supreme Court case, write formal **opening and closing statements**, and support their position with evidence cited on a **works-cited page**. Because the unit folds the old Constitution, Checks & Balances, and SCOTUS units into one arc, students reach the debate already fluent in the branches, judicial review, and the Bill of Rights.

Standards: C2.6-8.5 (checks & balances through a real case) · C4.6-8.4 (individual rights vs. common good) · C1.6-8.3 (constitutional ideals) · SSS3.6-8.1 (deliberation) · SSS4.6-8.1 & SSS4.6-8.2 (thesis + citation).

Anchor 2 — the Civic Action throughline (Semester 2)

A one-week civic-action project isn't realistic for middle schoolers, so this runs as a **term-long throughline** powered by the weekly current-events routine, with only the final assembly happening at the end. How it works:

- **Curated issues.** Week 1 of Semester 2, students choose a present-day national issue from a menu you pre-vet (with leveled sources attached) — voting rights, immigration, labor, tribal/treaty rights, free expression, and more.
- **Research pods.** Students on the same issue form a small pod that pools weekly current-events finds, lowering the reading load — but each keeps their own Issue File and builds their own product.
- **A lens per unit.** Each unit adds a historical angle on the same issue: economic policy (U4), land & Indigenous rights (U5), citizenship & rights (U6), labor & immigration (U7), and how movements organize for change (U8).
- **Choice-board finish.** In Unit 8 students synthesize the Issue File into a Civic Action Product chosen from a tiered menu — every path graded on one common rubric.

Civic Action choice board

Same thinking from every student — claim, evidence from the Issue File, and a real action — demonstrated through the lane that fits their strengths. **Tiers:** **Entry** (lower language load) · **Core** (grade-level) · **Stretch** (challenge).

Mode	Entry	Core	Stretch
Write	Picture book for younger kids	Letter to a representative	Op-ed
Speak	Interview + reflection	PSA or town-hall speech	Podcast episode
Make	Annotated map or cartoon	Infographic poster	Social-media campaign
Do	Flyer + awareness plan	Solution one-pager	Mock bill / policy proposal

Common rubric for every path: Claim · Evidence from the Issue File · Action & Audience · Citations (C4.6-8.5, H4.6-8.3, SSS4.6-8.1, SSS4.6-8.2).

Unit-by-unit detail

Unit 1 — Foundations & Identity Weeks 1–3 · Sep 2–18 · pre-1763

Driving question: *Who gets to define what an “American” is — and whose stories get told?*

Signature project: “Whose America?” — a life-map identity piece that expands into the three colonial regions and the perspectives of Indigenous and enslaved people. Establishes the year’s “whose voice?” habit and the Classroom Constitution.

Core content: Identity, classroom norms, the three colonial regions, contact and the Columbian Exchange, an introduction to the Triangle Trade.

Standards: G1.6-8.5 · H3.6-8.4 · C4.6-8.4 · E1.6-8.3 · SSS3.6-8.1

Gap / throughline: *Launches perspective-taking; plants the first economics seed (profit vs. values in the Triangle Trade).*

Unit 2 — Revolution: Ideas & Voices Weeks 4–8 · Sep 21–Oct 23 · 1763–1783

Driving question: *What made independence worth fighting for — and for whom was it left incomplete?*

Signature project: The Voices of the Revolution podcast: students research an overlooked Revolutionary figure, build a thesis, and cite sources — your existing SSS4 anchor.

Core content: Causes and grievances, the Declaration of Independence (close read), Patriot vs. Loyalist perspectives, overlooked voices, and the failure of the Articles of Confederation.

Standards: H1.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.5 · H3.6-8.4 · C1.6-8.3 · C1.6-8.4 · SSS2 · SSS4

Gap / throughline: *Reinforces multiple perspectives and the research-to-product skill chain that the CBA will demand next.*

Unit 3 — Building a Government (Civics CBA) Weeks 9–19 · Oct 26–Jan 22 · 1781–1815

Driving question: *How do you build a government that limits its own power — and who decides what the Constitution means?*

Signature project: The Constitutional Issues CBA, delivered as the SCOTUS debate: opening and closing statements arguing a constitutional question through a landmark case, with cited evidence and a works-cited page.

Core content: Articles of Confederation’s failure, the Convention and its compromises, the structure of the Constitution, the Bill of Rights, the three branches and checks & balances, judicial review, and landmark cases. (Folds in the former Checks & Balances and SCOTUS units.)

Standards: C1.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.3 · C2.6-8.5 · C2.6-8.6 · C4.6-8.4 · SSS3 · SSS4

Gap / throughline: *Consolidates three former units into one assessed arc and satisfies the required Civics CBA.*

Unit 4 — A New Nation & Its Economy Weeks 20–23 · Jan 26–Feb 19 · 1789–1840s

Driving question: *What kind of nation — and economy — would the young United States become?*

Signature project: “Founding an Economy”: a cabinet decision-simulation around Hamilton’s financial plan — the national bank, assuming state debts, the first tariffs, and the whiskey tax that sparked rebellion.

Core content: Presidential precedents, early foreign policy and the War of 1812, the start of the Market Revolution, and the economic debates that defined the parties.

Standards: E3.6-8.3 · E2.6-8.6 · E4.6-8.6 · E1.6-8.3 · C3.6-8.5 · C3.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.7

Gap / throughline: *Lands four of the five economics gaps. Throughline begins: students choose their Civic Action issue and view it through an economic-policy lens.*

Unit 5 — Expansion & Its Costs Weeks 24–27 · Feb 22–Mar 19 · 1801–1850

Driving question: *What drove the nation westward, and who paid the price?*

Signature project: A layered-map and perspectives study: students overlay territorial growth, migration routes, Indigenous nations, and resource patterns, then weigh Manifest Destiny against the people it displaced.

Core content: The Louisiana Purchase, Manifest Destiny, Indian Removal, the Mexican-American War, and patterns of migration and settlement.

Standards: G1.6-8.6 · G2.6-8.6 · G2.6-8.8 · G3.6-8.3 · H2.6-8.6 · H3.6-8.4 · H1.6-8.6

Gap / throughline: Closes the geography gaps (maps that explain dynamics; cultural diffusion; geography and global issues). Throughline lens: land and Indigenous rights.

Unit 6 — A Nation Divided

Weeks 28–31 · Mar 22–Apr 23 · 1850–1877

Driving question: *Why did the nation tear itself apart, and what did Reconstruction try to rebuild?*

Signature project: A causation analysis in which students build a claim about the war's causes using political, social, AND economic evidence — treating the cotton economy and enslaved labor as a supply-and-demand system.

Core content: Sectionalism, the cotton economy and tariffs, the road to war, the war itself, Reconstruction, and the Reconstruction Amendments.

Standards: H1.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.5 · H2.6-8.6 · H2.6-8.7 · H3.6-8.5 · E4.6-8.5 · E2.6-8.5 · C1.6-8.4

Gap / throughline: Adds the missing Reconstruction content and the cotton/tariff economics. Throughline lens: citizenship and rights (the 13th–15th Amendments).

Unit 7 — A Changing Nation

Weeks 32–35 · Apr 26–May 21 · 1877–1915

Driving question: *How did industry, cities, and immigration remake America — and who built it?*

Signature project: “Building Modern America”: a museum-style exhibit project in which teams curate the era — industrialization, urban life, immigration, and labor — combining the three former back-third themes into one build.

Core content: Industrialization and new technology, the growth of cities, immigration (Ellis Island, nativism), the labor movement, and the gap between industrialists and workers.

Standards: H2.6-8.7 · H2.6-8.6 · E2.6-8.5 · G2.6-8.6 · G2.6-8.7 · G2.6-8.8

Gap / throughline: New content your site was missing; closes cultural diffusion (G2.6-8.7) and strengthens the technology/ideas standard. Throughline lens: labor and immigration.

Unit 8 — Reform & Civic Action

Weeks 36–40 · May 24–Jun 22 · 1890–today

Driving question: *How have everyday people made change — and how will you?*

Signature project: The Civic Action Project: students study how Progressive-era reformers won change, then synthesize their term-long Issue File into a choice-board product (claim + evidence + a real action).

Core content: Progressive-era reforms, muckrakers, the suffrage movement, and the mechanics of how movements organize — studied as models for students' own action.

Standards: C4.6-8.5 · C4.6-8.4 · H4.6-8.3 · H2.6-8.5 · SSS3 · SSS4

Gap / throughline: Closes the biggest civics gap (civic action on a national issue) and the history-to-today gap. The throughline culminates here.

Standards coverage check: gaps now closed

Every gap flagged in the original alignment analysis now has a home in the realigned map.

Standard	Was the gap	Now addressed in
C4.6-8.5	Civic action on a national issue	Civic Action throughline + Unit 8 product
E3.6-8.3	U.S. taxation, currency & tariffs	Unit 4 — “Founding an Economy”
E2.6-8.6	Supply & demand in U.S. trade	Units 4 & 7
E4.6-8.6	Costs/benefits of U.S. trade policy	Unit 4
E1.6-8.3	Profit vs. personal values	Units 1 & 4
G1.6-8.6	Maps that explain dynamics	Unit 5 — layered map study
G2.6-8.7	Cultural diffusion in the U.S.	Unit 7 — immigration & cities
G3.6-8.3	Geography & global issues	Unit 5
H4.6-8.3	History informs today’s issues	Weekly “Now & Then” + Unit 8
H2.6-8.7	Technology & ideas in U.S. history	Units 4, 6 & 7 (now explicit)

One scope note worth naming

Units 7 and 8 run to roughly 1915–1920, past the 1877 endpoint of the History chronology standard (**H1.6-8.6**). That is intentional: it follows your district’s Revolution-to-Reform course description, and those units still serve the History causation and perspective standards (H2, H3), Geography, Economics, and Civics — they simply sit beyond H1’s named era list. Worth stating plainly in any department or pacing conversation.

Pacing & flex

The map fills 40 instructional weeks (180 student days) but is designed to breathe. Your wiggle room lives in four places:

- **The weekly routine.** “Now & Then” is only 15 minutes, leaving the rest of each week for unit work — and it carries the Civic Action research so the project never needs its own block.
- **Breaks do useful work.** Winter Break (Dec 21–Jan 1) falls between the CBA build and the CBA debates, so students return to perform the Constitutional CBA that closes Semester 1 on Jan 22. Spring Break (Apr 5–9) splits the heavy Civil War unit. Grading dates are built in: End Q1 Nov 6, End Q3 Apr 2.
- **Project arcs, not daily tasks.** Each unit is a 3–4 week arc (Unit 3 runs longer to fold in the Convention, checks & balances, and the CBA) with float days you can spend on reteaching or extension.
- **A named relief valve.** If the back third tightens, Units 7 and 8 can merge into a single “Modern America & Reform” project without losing the throughline. Snow make-up days (May 28, June 23–28) sit as buffer beyond the plan.

Source: *OSPI K–12 Social Studies Learning Standards (2019), Grades 6–8, and the OSPI Recommended Scope & Sequence (2020).* Standard codes match the interactive *Standards Progression Map* on Mr. B’s site.